

Special Meeting of the Medford School Committee

Monday, April 25, 2022

5:00 PM

To be held via Zoom:

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Agenda

- I. Roll Call for Attendance of Members and the Student Representatives
- II. Salute the Flag
- III. MSBA - In continuation of the previous discussions on March 21, 2022 and April 11, 2022 concerning the district's intention to submit a Statement of Interest to the Massachusetts School Building Authority's (MSBA) Core Program on behalf of Medford High School, the School Committee will be asked to approve the following motion thereby authorizing the administration to formally submit the MHS Statement of Interest:

MSBA REQUIRED FORM OF VOTE TO SUBMIT STATEMENT OF INTEREST

Resolved: Having convened in an open meeting on April 25, 2022, prior to the SOI submission closing date, the School Committee of the City of Medford, in accordance with its charter, by-laws, and ordinances, has voted to authorize Superintendent Marice Edouard-Vincent to submit to the Massachusetts School Building Authority the Statement of Interest Form dated April 2022 for Medford High School located at 489 Winthrop Street which describes and explains the following deficiencies and the priority categories for which an application may be submitted to the Massachusetts School Building Authority in the future.

The Medford School Committee hereby further specifically acknowledges that by submitting this Statement of Interest Form, the Massachusetts School Building Authority in no way guarantees the acceptance or the approval of an application, the awarding of a grant or any other funding commitment

from the Massachusetts School Building Authority, or commits the City of Medford to filing an application for funding with the Massachusetts School Building Authority.

Medford High School MSBA Core Program Statement of Interest Summary:

Statutory Priority # 5: Replacement, renovation or modernization of school facility systems, such as roofs, windows, boilers, heating and ventilation systems, to increase energy conservation and decrease energy related costs in a school facility.

Having been originally constructed in 1970 and with substantial portions of the building's infrastructure dating from that time, Medford High School's (MHS) operating systems, including but not limited to its pneumatic-controlled HVAC systems, roofs, windows, plumbing, and electrical systems have long outlived their useful life expectancy and/or are in poor working condition. In addition to major energy deficiency challenges posed by these antiquated systems, which were identified recently in a facilities condition assessment, the MHS facility features suboptimal ADA accessibility, fire safety, security and technological aspects that would potentially be addressed through an MSBA partnership.

MPS seeks to submit this Statement of Interest to explore possible remedies to environmental challenges plaguing MHS attributable to highly antiquated systems like single pane windows and plumbing and heating systems that have too frequently proved inadequate to withstand the fluctuations in weather patterns that are inevitable in the greater Medford area. In addition to escalating and wasteful utilities expenses, extreme temperatures and leaky or burst pipes have yielded significant disruptions to learning environments for students and educators.

When students returned to in-person learning in school year 2020 - 2021 after the pandemic-related shutdowns, MPS made a concerted effort to repair HVAC systems in order to meet heightened air quality standards that were believed to help mitigate the spread of COVID-19. These efforts along with an emphasis on fresh air to increase the frequency of air exchanges in confined spaces put additional pressure on HVAC systems that by virtue of their age alone were overly taxed. In the aforementioned report, MHS was estimated to expend 77% more energy than an average American school facility. While MPS will continue to identify ways to identify energy efficiency strategies in the short term, the continued reliance on a 600,000 square foot facility that now houses a fraction of the student population it once did will continue to pose major challenges from an energy conservation perspective.

Finally, while frequent air quality testing and environmental analysis has continued to demonstrate that MHS is currently a safe environment for students and staff, the materials used to build the school over 50 years ago yield considerable challenges with respect to costs and the removal of hazardous materials in the event of significant repair work, which given the poor

functioning electrical and plumbing infrastructure represents an ongoing considerable financial risk.

Statutory Priority # 7: Replacement of or addition to obsolete buildings in order to provide for a full range of programs consistent with state and approved local requirements.

In 2017, after decades of functioning as two distinct schools housed in one building, the Medford School Committee voted to merge Medford High School and Medford Technical Vocational High School into one comprehensive high school featuring a broad array of academic and approved ch. 74 vocational programming. Since that time, MHS has seen an increasing number of students choose to commit to studying in one of Medford's 15 approved ch. 74 vocational programs, rising from 22% of the eligible students in school year 2017 - 2018 to 45% today. This increasing investment and interest on the part of Medford students and families in vocational programming has made the full integration and cohesion of the entire school community an urgent priority for the Medford Public Schools.

In addition to the climate and logistical challenges posed by the environment deficiencies referenced above, the antiquated infrastructure of MHS has also posed instructional and enrollment challenges in light of the increasing competitiveness of the school's vocational programs. Several of the ch. 74 programs lack adequate related classroom space, which significantly diminishes educators' ability to convene groups of students to engage in focused discussions on the disciplines they are learning. In addition, several programs, including but not limited to Health Assisting and Electrical, have found their enrollments necessarily capped due to a scarcity of space in their labs and shops.

In addition to the district's inability to provide seats in existing programs commensurate with the level of interest, a recent analysis by the Metro North Workforce Board has urged the consideration of the development of additional ch. 74 programs including but not necessarily limited to Plumbing, Animal Science, Dental Assisting, and Information Support Services/Networking. Given the exploding popularity of the school's existing programs, and the interest being expressed in these and other prospective programs, there is a compelling basis to consider the development and adoption of additional programs in environments that are well situated for students to gain mastery of these workforce-sustaining educational pathways.

In addition to the need to meet the demands of the Medford community by offering a full complement of vocational programming, MPS is eager to consider ways to more fully integrate what were once two schools into a comprehensive school community that positions students to leverage their exposure to a diverse array of both academic and vocational programming in an environment that is well-suited to meet their instructional needs. To that end the aforementioned environmental deficiencies that lead to wildly fluctuating temperatures and classes that are routinely relocated to other sections of the building due to burst pipes, damaged heating coils, or

failing technology systems has become an all-too-common distraction to the educational environment that MHS students require. In addition to these types of distractions, the building's culture is negatively affected by an antiquated architectural structure in which over one third of the learning environments offer either no or virtually no natural light.

Students have frequently described their flagship school as bleak with a persistent sense of foreboding that is exacerbated by multiple undersized cafeterias that cause supervisory challenges to staff and logistical challenges for students seeking fresh and hot meals. Venues that should serve as hospitable gathering places for the school community like the auditorium and lecture halls are instead associated with constantly malfunctioning HVAC systems that diminish both opportunities for learning and the overall school culture.

Finally, while the district has invested in staffing and security cameras to help ensure the school's physical safety, the lack of optimal security infrastructure constitutes a subtle but persistent distraction to students. This deficiency is indicative of how the school's aging and deteriorating infrastructure has affected both the development of educational programs and the capacity for students and staff to thrive from a teaching and learning perspective within those programs.

IV. Next Meeting

- **Monday, May 2, 2022, 6:00PM: Regular School Committee Meeting** - Alden Memorial Chambers, Medford City Hall in addition to zoom: <https://mps02155-org.zoom.us/j/91728927112>

V. Adjournment